I was told that I was speaking to the editor himself. So, making a reference to the Sahara motto ‘Duty, Patriotism and Altruism’, I asked him which of these three was involved in this kind of journalism. He asked me who I was. I introduced myself and demanded an explanation. I said, ‘You haven’t bothered to quote any source but as an interested party I have a right to know where you got your information from.’ There was silence. Then I gave him a short lecture on journalistic ethics (which I will not bore you with) and also threatened to sue him. He then said that the editor was not there and that he would tell him about my complaint when he returned. He tried to sound sympathetic by saying that it was really serious and he would take it up with the editor and let me know. Then he asked for my phone number, but by then I was so furious that I just slammed the receiver down.

Here was a newspaper which was unashamedly indulging in defamation. Now the media construction of the mastermind was complete. Geelani had been transformed into an ‘intellectual terrorist’ with influence from Aligarh to London, and an ideologue of the Jaish- e-Mohammad in India. I wonder why other newspapers did not carry this story as well. Surely *Rashtriya Sahara* did not have exclusive sources on Geelani. Or did the other journalists find these revelations too far-fetched?

On 20 December 2001 the *Times of India* carried a single-column story entitled ‘Geelani Was in Bhuj with SIMI Group’.[14] The story was datelined Ahmedabad and quoted the Kutch District Police as its source. This story was meant to link Geelani to the banned Students’ Islamic Organization of India (SIMI), and create an image that would shock. There is no way Geelani or any of us could have countered this kind of falsehood. We just read these reports each day with growing concern about Geelani’s future.

The next day the newspapers and the electronic media were once again full of stories about the three accused. The journalists had been invited to the Lodi Road Police Station (the office of the Special Cell) for a media conference. Mohammad Afzal was forced to address it and incriminate himself before the entire country. The *Hindustan Times* had a seven-column headline, screaming ‘Pak Uses Fanatics to Spread Terror in India’.[15] The story was by Neeta Sharma.

On top of the story was a banner with a one- column bold heading in red, titled ‘Confession Time’, and then a photo of the three accused along with a quote from their ‘confession’. Along with Geelani’s photo was this quote: ‘I